There were times when he consciously placed us under pressure in training. Boxing was one of his ideas. He liked to see us sweat, and deal with a little adversity. The group respected that, and dealt with the highly organized aspects of his approach. Team meetings can be a pain, and repetitive work is usually boring, but they breed an understanding of what is expected.

Rewards, when they arrive, are all the sweeter. We had a ten-day break to digest the lessons of Leeds before we took to the field at the Oval, that traditional stage for the last boys of summer. Broady made initial inroads with a trademark, consistently hostile five-wicket spell. Trotty became the eighteenth England player to make a century on his debut, and Australia needed 546 to win in little more than two days.

Freddie, writing his own script to the last, was responsible for the turning point. He broke a troublesome fourth-wicket stand of 127 by running out Ricky Ponting with a direct hit from mid-on. As we closed in on victory, I was sent to Boot Hill, short leg to the uninitiated. It is not a place for the slow-witted or the faint hearted.

You are taught to stay low and to stay alert. My first experience of being hit on the head in Test-match cricket came against the Australians in 2006. It was nearly my last. Adam Gilchrist, a brilliant sweeper of the ball, splintered my protective helmet, which went flying. It gave me every incentive to learn from my mistake, in turning my back instead of having the presence of mind to duck.

The key is not to tense up, and to anticipate the shot the batsmen intends to play. You try to read body shape in a split second, but occasionally make yourself look silly in unnecessarily taking evasive action. That’s when everyone laughs at you and why, when you’ve done your time, you tend to look for safer pastures.

Slower bowlers who are harder to sweep, like Swanny and Monty Panesar, are appreciated. The thrill of the chase, when they are attacking, with victory in sight, compensates for the occasional perilous drag down. Swanny secured the Ashes in trademark style, forcing Mike Hussey to nick one to me at short leg after a 328-minute vigil for 121.

I still smile when I see the photograph that captures the moment. We are running madly, indiscriminately, in triumph, arms aloft and screaming with joy. What the image doesn’t reveal is my animal cunning, in putting the ball straight into my pocket. I had not forgotten the enduring regret of my old